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# Dr. Riya Bhattacharya

## Academic Profile

Urban and human geography scholar working on **suburban and peri-urban change**, migration and local governance in India. Trained in geography at Presidency University, Kolkata, and qualified for the **UGC-NET Junior Research Fellowship in Geography**, I combine primary fieldwork with **GIS-based spatial analysis** to study how metropolitan peripheries grow and how municipal institutions respond. My doctoral research examines service delivery and citizen participation across suburban municipalities of the Kolkata Metropolitan Area, using household surveys, regression analysis and geospatial methods. At M.S. Ramaiah University of Applied Sciences, I designed and taught postgraduate courses in quantitative methods and urban governance, and led students in **field-based GIS mapping** of flood hotspots in Bengaluru. My publications appear in **SSCI- and Scopus-indexed journals**, including the *Singapore Journal of Tropical Geography* and the *Journal of Urban Affairs*. I also review for geography journals, including *GeoJournal* and *Letters in Spatial and Resource Sciences*.

## Eligibility

**UGC-NET Junior Research Fellowship (Geography)**, University Grants Commission June 2020

**Ph.D.** awarded by the University of Mysore August 2026

## Education

**Institute for Social and Economic Change** Bengaluru
*Ph.D., Development Studies (University of Mysore)* 2021 – 2026

- Thesis: **Decentralised Governance, Participation and Service Delivery: A Study of Extended Metropolitan Kolkata**
- Advisor: Prof. D. Rajasekhar
- Methods: primary household surveys, geospatial analysis, index construction, probit/OLS regression and narrative analysis
- Degree awarded: August 2026, in accordance with UGC Regulations

**Department of Geography, Presidency University** Kolkata
*M.Sc., Geography* 2018 – 2020

- Dissertation: **Suburban Dynamics: A Study of Dankuni Municipality**
- Percentage: 73.70

**Gokhale Memorial Girls' College, University of Calcutta** Kolkata
*B.Sc., Geography* 2015 – 2018

- Percentage: 67.00; Top Scorer, Abhijit Bhattacharya Memorial Prize

## Teaching Experience

**Adjunct Faculty** August 2025 – Present
**Department of Public Policy**, *M.S. Ramaiah University of Applied Sciences*, Bengaluru
**Courses designed and taught:** Quantitative Methods and Data Analytics in Public Policy (MAC525A); Public Policy and Urban Governance

**Field-based teaching:** Led MA students in a field study of how drain flooding and traffic in Bengaluru affect the daily commute of university workers. Students surveyed university staff and mapped flooding hotspots using GIS, combining primary field data with spatial analysis.

**Student feedback** (MAC525A, PG Even Semester 2026): course evaluation average of **4.42/5 (88.4%)** across all parameters (5 of 7 enrolled students responding), with the highest score for course notes and handouts at **4.6/5 (92%)**. Comments included *"she's excellent"* and *"made coding simpler and easier."*

## Courses I Can Offer in Geography

**Urban Geography:** urbanisation, suburbanisation and peri-urban growth, metropolitan regions, informal settlements and urban service provision, drawn from my published research on suburban Kolkata.

**Population and Settlement Geography:** theories and measures of population growth, migration, population ageing, types and patterns of settlement, and rural–urban development, informed by my work on an ICSSR project on family size and ageing in India and Japan.

**Political Geography and Geography of Local Governance:** territory, decentralisation and the local state, municipal boundaries and metropolitan governance, drawn from my doctoral research and publications.

**Economic Geography:** theories of location, resources, agriculture, industry and transport geography.

**Social and Cultural Geography:** religious, linguistic and ethnic distribution of population, and gender and space.

**Geographical Thought:** from the ancient to the modern era; pragmatism, radical, humanistic, Marxist, feminist and behavioural approaches in geography.

**Environmental Geography and Urban Hazards:** urban flooding, heat stress, climate risk and vulnerability mapping, building on my field-based flood mapping in Bengaluru.

**GIS and Spatial Analysis:** spatial data handling, thematic mapping, hotspot analysis and geoprocessing in ArcGIS and QGIS, with scripting in Python (ArcPy).

**Remote Sensing and Cartography:** principles of remote sensing, visual and digital image interpretation, land use and land cover classification, map projections and thematic cartography.

**Physical Geography (undergraduate level):** Geomorphology, Climatology.

**Quantitative Techniques in Geography:** sampling, descriptive and inferential statistics, index construction and regression (OLS/probit) in R and Stata.

**Field Techniques and Survey Methods:** questionnaire design, household and institutional surveys, and GIS-based field mapping, modelled on my field teaching at RUAS.

**Research Methodology in Geography:** qualitative data analysis, conducting in-depth interviews, focus group discussions, participant observation, narrative analysis, grounded theory and ethnography.

**Additional:** Regional Planning and Development.

## Research Experience

**Research Associate** June 2026 – Present
**ICSSR Major Project:** *Family Size, Ageing and Economic Development: A Comparative Analysis of India and Japan*
*M.S. Ramaiah University of Applied Sciences*, Bengaluru

**Research Project** September 2022 – September 2024
**What Factors Influence the Performance of Women Leaders in Urban Local Bodies? A Study of Two Municipalities in West Bengal**
Under the supervision of Prof. D. Rajasekhar, *Institute for Social and Economic Change*, Bengaluru

## Journal Articles

1. **Bhattacharya, Riya,** & Rajasekhar, D. (2025). Factors influencing citizen participation in ward committee meetings: Evidence from Suburban India. *Journal of Urban Affairs*, 48(8), 2668–2690. https://doi.org/10.1080/07352166.2025.2560954 **[SSCI, Scopus]**
2. **Bhattacharya, Riya** (2025). Citizen participation in suburbs: A study of Dankuni municipality, West Bengal. *Journal of Social and Economic Development*. https://doi.org/10.1007/s40847-025-00449-6 **[Scopus]**
3. **Bhattacharya, Riya,** & Guin, D. (2024). Suburban dynamics: A study of migration and governance in suburban Kolkata. *Singapore Journal of Tropical Geography*, 45(3), 426–446. https://doi.org/10.1111/sjtg.12560 **[SSCI, Scopus]**

## Book Chapter

1. **Bhattacharya, Riya** (2024). What Factors Influence the Performance of Women Leaders in Urban Local Bodies? A Study of Two Municipalities in West Bengal. In *Women Leadership, Decentralised Governance and Development: Perspectives from Indian States* (pp. 115–135). Springer Nature, Singapore. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-981-97-3709-3_7

## Peer-Reviewed Working Papers

1. **Bhattacharya, Riya** (2024). Urban Service Delivery in India: Status and Issues. *ISEC Working Paper* No. 594. ISBN 978-93-93879-57-8.
2. **Bhattacharya, Riya** (2022). Ward Committees as "Invited Space": Is It Successful? A Literature Review of Urban India. *ISEC Working Paper* No. 546. ISBN 978-93-93879-18-9.

## Op-Eds

1. Heatwaves and Floods Expose India's Urban Policy Gaps. *Policy Circle*, (2026).
2. Digitising Urban Governance: The End of the Middleman Era? *Policy Circle*, (2025).

## Work in Progress

1. Why do we need to move beyond coverage of service delivery? A study of metropolitan peripheries in India. *[Under Review]*
2. Paradox in the periphery: Financial condition and spatial indentation of municipalities of Kolkata. *[Draft]*
3. Factors influencing basic service delivery in the periphery of metropolitan Kolkata, West Bengal. *[Draft]*
4. State capacity and schooling: The role of governance in educational attainment (with Dr. Kaibalyapati Mishra). *[Draft]*

## Conference Presentations

1. *Determinants of Basic Service Delivery in the Cities of Metropolitan Peripheries of Kolkata*. **International Conference on New Approaches to Governance and Resilience (NAGAR)**, School of Human Settlements, XIM University, Bhubaneswar February 2026
2. *Paradox in the Periphery: Financial Condition and Spatial Indentation of Municipalities of Suburban Kolkata*. **45th Annual Conference, Centre for Urban Economic Studies (CUES)**, University of Calcutta January 2026
3. *Challenges of governing public water supply: A study of suburban Kolkata*. **International Conference on Urban Water Management: Policies and Praxis**, Department of Political Science, University of Delhi February 2025
4. *Factors influencing citizen participation in two municipalities of suburban Kolkata*. **IPSA 75th Anniversary Conference, Challenges and New Directions in Multi-Level Governance**, Concordia University, Montreal April 2024
5. *Towards effective participation in Urban Local Governance: Understanding the ways and factors*. **International Conference on Urban Policy**, CHRIST University, Bengaluru April 2023
6. *Women Leaders in Urban Local Bodies: An Evaluation of Performance and factors influencing Leadership*. **National Seminar on Women Leadership in Decentralised Governance**, ISEC, Bengaluru November 2022
7. *Suburban Governance: A Study of Dankuni Municipality*. **4th International Graduate Seminar on the Quality of Living in Informal Settlements**, TISS, Hyderabad April 2021

## Training

**Pandemic and Southern City II**, Hyderabad Urban Lab March 2021

**Programming ArcGIS with Python**, Computer Aided Design Centre, Jadavpur University Dec 2020 – Feb 2021

## Skills

**GIS:** `ArcGIS, QGIS, Python (ArcPy)`

**Statistics and qualitative analysis:** `R (RStudio), Stata, NVivo`

**Languages:** English (Fluent), Hindi (Fluent), Bengali (Native)

## Awards and Fellowships

- **Research Conference Travel Grant**, Indian Council of Social Science Research 2024
- **Dr. D. M. Nanjundappa Endowment Prize**, Gold Medal in Pre-PhD Coursework, Institute for Social and Economic Change 2022
- **Junior Research Fellowship (UGC-NET, Geography)**, University Grants Commission 2020
- **Abhijit Bhattacharya Memorial Prize**, Top Scorer, B.Sc. Geography, Gokhale Memorial Girls' College 2018

## Peer Review

1. Reviewer for *Singapore Journal of Tropical Geography*, *GeoJournal*, *Letters in Spatial and Resource Sciences*, *Development in Practice* and *Contemporary South Asia*.